



World's worst airplanes

History of aviation is littered with horrible plane ideas. Here are the worst airplane designs: <http://digit.in/1vR8kC8>

World's cheapest Zero-G flight

If you need to experience weightlessness, the quickest and cheapest alternative is no longer Russia, but a company in Switzerland: <http://digit.in/1onruLD>

Mxit Well

In conversation with Sam Rufus Nallaraj, Francois Swart and Roger Grobler about the future of Mxit – a social networking app with a twist

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What do you think differentiates Mxit from the other apps other than the fact that it runs on feature phones as well?

SRN: That is in fact fundamentally a huge differentiating factor, specially for us, in India. Market wise, if you see the potential, out of 900 million users in India, there are barely about 185-200 million on Smartphone. But the untapped potential that is there is close to 550 million and the rest about 150 million are the 'dumb' phones. But the remaining 500 million phones have 2G data access and the ability to download Mxit and start chatting. So we believe that it is fundamentally a huge market for us.

But there are other apps out there, like Nimbuzz and a few others, that work on feature phones as well, aren't there?

Francois Swart: Well, there's only really Facebook that parallels us on the amount of feature phones that we work on, because we've been there right from the beginning. So that with all old models run all the way from the old feature phones to the new smartphones. Another thing that we like to differentiate ourselves is obviously localness. A part of that is that we want to be in 11 official languages in India. We've launched with Hindi, but in the next six months we want to add another 10. And then the big component: we say we are a social network but we've coined the phrase 'Social Squared'. It's not just chatting, but it's also the social things we do around education,

health care and counselling apps we have on Mxit. So inside Africa today, we've got around 27 million counselling sessions on Mxit. Where users have been able to speak to a social worker/counsellor on the other side. For rape counselling, for abuse, for drug abuse, for teenage pregnancy. So we believe it is a big differentiator or differentiating factor to other social networks out there. The other thing is that you also have the ability to stay anonymous on Mxit. So when it comes to the social side of things, people don't like to open up when they know that you're revealing your true identity. So in the Mxit environment, you can be anonymous and communicate with that



Sam Rufus Nallaraj

person anonymously and get counselling services. So we believe in the counselling and we want to try that in India too. It gives us a local flair and actually puts us on the ground in the communities – Not on the ground with a clipboard, but a mobile phone that gives us real leverage.

P: Where do you see Mxit five years from now?

SRN: Personally, I'm very excited about our AI bot, the integration of what it can do and achieve. Secondly, the shift to wearable technology in five years from now. We want to be geared up for that kind of technology which has a different scale of integration. So we want to be present there at those key areas.

FS: I think from a geographic perspective, India is our spring board into Asia. And



Francois Swart

there's a massive market there. Now if we do well in India, then all the countries around here are our natural next target. From an African perspective, Nigeria is a big target for us. India was a part of BRICS and Nigeria's similarly a part of MINT – Mexico, Indonesia, Nigeria and Turkey. Our priorities are quite different from other social network approaches, because we believe that localization is important and to be able to do localization properly, you need to be on the ground. So we're focusing on India and Nigeria for our expansion plans, at this stage.

Roger Grobler: The difference between the Indian market and any other market is probably that there are at least a billion people that are not connected to the internet, today. And the only way we're going to get them connected is via



Roger Grobler

mobile phones. These mobile phones are largely already in their hands – so they've got the internet in their hands, but they're not using it! It's natural for most people. You want to find something, you Google it, you get a bunch of links, you decide what you want to click on, you get to a structured website. If you've never done that before it's not

all that obvious. What we think MXIT provides is quite a human interface to the internet. It's not that chaotic as the internet is at the moment, and from a five-year perspective – it is growing at an accelerated rate. We'd be keen to drive that rate even faster and get even more people connected. So if in five years time if most of the people in India can get online, that's a great outcome. It really changes the lifestyle of people with access to information today. One of the reasons why we think that this inflection is happening now. **d**